
The Gen AI Money Playbook.

How to turn what you learned over the weekend into real income — through freelancing, products, content, agencies, and roles that didn't exist twenty-four months ago.

A FIELD MANUAL FOR



Builders, freelancers and founders



India-first, global-ready



Read time: **45 minutes** — then re-read every quarter



Eight paths · USD pricing · 90-day roadmap

// WHAT'S INSIDE

Inside the playbook.

Twenty sections. Eight monetization paths. One field-tested operating system for turning AI skill into income.

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// LETTER TO THE ATTENDEE

You did the weekend. Now do the work.

Over the past two days you were handed something most professionals will not touch for another two years: a working command of foundation models, custom GPTs, Gemini Gems, prompt engineering, vibe-coding, and image-and-video generation workflows. That is the input. **This document is the output.**

The truth is uncomfortable: most people who attend a workshop will go home, post a celebratory selfie, and never ship. The skills decay. The tab gets closed. Six months later, the only thing that survived the weekend is the certificate.

This playbook exists so that does not happen to you. It is a tactical, opinionated map for converting what you now know into dollars — through eight distinct paths, with platforms, prices, scripts, and a 90-day roadmap. You will not need to do all eight. You will need to **pick one, commit for ninety days, and ship publicly**. That is the whole game.

How to use this

Read pages 04–05 to orient. Skim pages 06–13 (the eight paths). Pick one path that fits your life right now. Then operate from pages 14–20 — that's where the systems live. Re-read every quarter.

Who this is for

- **Working professionals** who want a side income or a path out of their current role.
- **Founders** who want to add an AI line item to their P&L this quarter.
- **Students** who want to graduate with paid client work, not just a CV.

Wherever you are, the rule is the same: *skill becomes income only when it touches the market*. Stop polishing in private. Start charging.

"The best time to monetize a skill is the week you learn it. The second-best time is right now."

// WHY THIS WINDOW MATTERS

A window most people will miss.

Every technology shift creates a small window where the people who learned early get paid disproportionately. Mobile (2009–2011). Cloud (2011–2014). Crypto (2017–2018). Gen AI is in that window right now — and in India, the gap between supply and demand is the widest it has ever been.

\$180

ENTRY FREELANCE

Typical first AI project for a working professional.

\$5K

GLOBAL CEILING

What a polished AI freelancer can charge per Custom GPT build on Upwork or Contra.

3M+

CUSTOM GPTS LIVE

In the GPT Store. Most are bad. The well-built, distributed ones win.

2×

SALARY UPLIFT

Common for in-house "AI champions" who automate workflows and own the narrative.

\$1.2K

PRODUCTIZED RETAINER

A single SMB client on a monthly AI ops retainer.

90d

TIME TO FIRST \$

Realistic timeline from "I just learned this" to first paying client, if you ship publicly.

Why most people still fail to monetize

01 They learn in private and never ship in public.

No portfolio, no proof, no inbound. The market cannot find you if you do not exist online.

02 They sell tools, not outcomes.

Nobody buys "I know ChatGPT." They buy "I will save your sales team 20 hours a week."

03 They stay generalist.

"AI for everyone" is "AI for nobody." The rupee is in the niche.

04 They under-price out of fear, then can't raise rates.

A \$35 client trains the market — and your nervous system — to expect \$35.

05 They wait to feel "ready."

Readiness is a feeling that arrives only after you have done the thing eleven times.

The reframe

You are not "*learning AI*." You are **arbitraging a skill gap**. Most teams in most companies in most cities still cannot prompt their way out of a paragraph. You can. *That gap is your business.*

// PICK ONE. COMMIT FOR 90 DAYS.

Eight ways to get paid for what you just learned.

Each path uses a different mix of the skills from the Mastermind. Each suits a different life stage. Read the table, find the row that fits, then jump to its deep-dive.

01	Freelance AI Specialist Sell your AI skills as bespoke project work — the fastest path to first revenue.	RANGE \$180-\$2.4K
02	Productized AI Services Same scope, same price, every time. Recurring monthly revenue without bespoke chaos.	/ MONTH \$500-\$3.6K
03	AI Creator & Personal Brand Build an audience around AI. Monetize through consults, courses, sponsorships and products.	YEAR 1 \$3.5K-\$36K
04	Vibe-Coded Micro-SaaS Use Cursor, v0, Lovable, Bolt to ship small, focused tools that earn \$5-\$50 / month each.	MRR TARGET \$500-10K
05	Custom GPTs & Gemini Gems Build niche assistants for specific workflows. Sell builds, sell access, or generate leads.	PER BUILD \$300-\$2.4K
06	AI Content & Video Production Image / video generation as a service for D2C brands, agencies, course creators, finance YTers.	/ MONTH \$350-\$1.8K
07		PER COHORT

Teach what you've shipped. Topmate, Skool, cohort courses, paid WhatsApp circles.

\$2.4K-\$30K

08 In-House AI Champion

UPLIFT

Stay employed. Become the AI person at your company. Negotiate a 30-100% comp uplift.

+30-100%

How to pick

Working professional with low spare time: **Path 01, 05, or 08**. Founder: **02 or 04**. Student: **01 → 03**. Already creating content: **03 + 07**.

The wrong path beaten to death beats the right path never started.

// PATH ONE · FASTEST PATH TO FIRST REVENUE

The Freelance AI Specialist.

Sell your AI skills as project work. This is the path with the lowest activation energy and the fastest time-to-revenue. Most attendees should start here, even if they end up at Path 02 or 03 long-term.

BEST FOR	TIME TO FIRST \$	INDIA RANGE	GLOBAL RANGE
Working pros · Students	2-6 weeks	\$180 - \$2.4K / project	\$500 - \$5K / project

Skills from the Mastermind, mapped to revenue

- **Prompting** → prompt engineering as a service.
- **Custom GPTs / Gems** → niche assistant builds.
- **Vibe-coding** → rapid landing pages, internal tools, MVPs.
- **Image / video gen** → ad creative, thumbnails, b-roll, course visuals.
- **Multiple AI models** → credible "I'll pick the right tool for your job."

Ten services you can sell this week

- 01 Custom GPT for a specific workflow.**
Sales prospecting, legal contract review, listing descriptions for real estate.
- 02 AI cold email / LinkedIn DM systems.**
Apollo + AI personalization, 1,000+ qualified sends a week.
- 03 Faceless YouTube content engines.**
Topic research → script → AI voice → AI b-roll. Hindi or English.
- 04 D2C ad creative packs.**

10–20 image/video ad variants per month for performance teams.

05 Internal AI training + SOPs for SMB teams.

Half-day workshop + Notion playbook + 3 custom GPTs.

06 Workflow automation (n8n / Make + AI).

Inbox triage, lead routing, content repurposing, reporting.

07 AI customer support chatbot.

Trained on the company's docs, deployed to website + WhatsApp.

08 Newsletter content engine setup.

Beehiiv / Substack + AI research and drafting flow.

09 SEO content engines.

Keyword research → outline → draft → polish. 20 articles a month.

10 Resume / LinkedIn / portfolio rewrites.

Lower-ticket but high-volume. Great for first 10 testimonials.

The 90-day launch sequence

DAYS 01-07 · NICHE

Pick one industry (D2C, real estate, edtech, law, finance creators). Build 3 spec pieces — fake client work that proves the outcome.

DAYS 08-14 · SETUP

Profile on Upwork + Contra + LinkedIn featured + Topmate. One vibe-coded portfolio page. Refrens for invoicing.

DAYS 15-30 · OUTBOUND

20 LinkedIn DMs / day · 10 cold emails / day · 3 posts / week. First 2–3 clients at \$180 each — go cheap, get testimonials.

DAYS 31-60 · REFINE

Raise prices 2×. Tighten niche. Document delivery. Ask happy clients for warm intros.

DAYS 61-90 · RETAINER

Convert 1–2 project clients into \$500+ / month retainers. Stop selling hours. Sell outcomes.

The Path 01 pitfall

The mistake every Path 01 freelancer makes is *hiding behind Upwork*. The real money is in LinkedIn DMs and warm intros, where there's no race-to-the-bottom bidding. Marketplaces are training wheels — get on, build proof, then ride out into direct outreach.

// PATH TWO · RECURRING REVENUE WITHOUT THE BESPOKE CHAOS

Productized AI Services.

A productized service is a service that behaves like a product. Same scope, same price, same delivery — every time. You stop quoting projects and start selling subscriptions. This is how the smartest freelancers escape the per-project grind.

BEST FOR	TIME TO LAUNCH	INDIA RETAINER	GLOBAL RETAINER
Founders · Senior freelancers	3-8 weeks	\$500 - \$3.6K / mo	\$1K - \$8K / mo

Productized offers that work in 2026

- 01

"AI-powered LinkedIn ghostwriting" — \$350 / month, 8 posts a week, voice-trained on the founder.

Hot for Indian founders, B2B sales heads, VCs. Repeatable, high-margin.
- 02

"Custom GPT for your team" — \$900 flat, two-week delivery, includes training and SOP.

Sells itself once you have one case study. Easy referrals inside companies.
- 03

"AI ad creative engine" — \$600 / month, 30 image + 10 video ad variants for D2C brands.

Performance marketers will pay for tested creative. Show CTR uplift.
- 04

"AI SEO content engine" — \$500 / month, 20 long-form articles, full pipeline.

Stack with Surfer / Frase / NeuronWriter. Charge by deliverable, not hours.
- 05

"Faceless YouTube channel-in-a-box" — \$1.8K setup + \$600 / month operations.

Hindi + English markets are wide open for finance, history, mythology, business niches.

06 "AI cold outbound system" — \$700 / month, 3,000 personalized emails, lead lists, deliverability.

B2B services and SaaS will pay for booked meetings, not "campaigns."

07 "AI customer support, deployed." — \$960 setup + \$300 / month maintenance.

SMB websites, D2C brands. Sell ticket-deflection % as the headline metric.

The productization framework

01 Pick.

Choose the one service from your freelance phase that you can deliver in your sleep, with the highest margin.

02 Document.

Write the SOP in Notion. Every step. Every prompt. Every tool. Make it reproducible.

03 Page.

Vibe-code a one-page sales site with v0 / Lovable. Hero · Outcome · Process · Price · CTA. Done.

04 Proof.

Two case studies — even if the first one is free for a friend's business. Numbers, not adjectives.

05 Distribute.

LinkedIn posts about the offer 3× a week + 50 cold DMs a week + 1 partnership a month.

06 Hire.

Once you hit 3 retainers, hire a contractor at 30% of revenue to deliver. Now you have a business.

The leap (the whole point of this path)

Productized services are how a freelancer stops being a freelancer. The math: 3 freelance clients at \$600 = \$1.8K — but you delivered all of it yourself. 3 retainer clients at \$600 = \$1.8K, delivered by a contractor at 30% cost = **\$1.25K of free time and margin.** That's the whole game.

// PATH THREE · COMPOUND DISTRIBUTION

The AI Creator.

An audience is the closest thing to financial superpower a single individual can build in 2026. The path is slow for the first six months and then it compounds violently. If you start now, you have a 12-month head start on most of your peers — including the ones who learned the same skills you did.

BEST FOR	TIME TO FIRST \$	YEAR 1 RANGE	YEAR 3 RANGE
Anyone with patience	3-9 months	\$3.5K - \$36K	\$36K - \$360K

Channels that work for AI creators

LinkedIn — India's B2B treasure

Best for: consulting income, B2B leads, hiring offers. Cadence: 5-7 posts a week. Carousel + native video + thought-piece text posts.

YouTube — long-form authority

Best for: course sales, sponsorships, deep trust. 1-2 videos a week, tutorial / "I tried X for 30 days" formats win.

X / Twitter — global tech audience

Best for: indie hacker / SaaS / global freelance. Ship-in-public, build-in-public, screenshots of receipts.

Instagram + YouTube Shorts — mass reach

Best for: course / cohort sales, India tier-2/3. Reels + carousels, 1 / day minimum.

Newsletter — your owned land

Best for: highest-intent monetization. Beehiiv or Substack. One every Sunday. The list is the asset.

Monetization, by audience stage

STAGE	HOW YOU EARN
0 - 1,000 followers	Free everything. Build proof. Collect testimonials. Do not monetize. Ship 5+ pieces a week.
1K - 5K followers	Soft monetization. Topmate consults at \$6-\$25 / 30 min. Free PDFs in exchange for emails. Affiliate links to AI tools.
5K - 25K followers	Owned products. Cohort courses (\$35-\$300 / seat). Sponsorships (\$120-\$1.2K / integration). Templates and Notion-style products.
25K - 100K+	Empire stage. Paid community, SaaS, agency, books, brand deals, advisory. Distribution is now your moat.

Content formulas that work

- "I tried [tool] for [time]. Here's what happened."
- "[Job role] in 2026 needs to know these 5 AI workflows."
- Before / after screenshots of a vibe-coded build.
- "\$0 to \$X with [path] — week-by-week breakdown."
- Negative-space contrarian takes against the hype.

The content law

You cannot half-ass this path. **5-7 pieces a week, minimum, for 6 months** before you judge whether it's working. Every creator who quits at month 3 was 90 days from compounding. Treat content as a non-negotiable, not a hobby.

// PATH FOUR · BUILD SMALL THINGS, COMPOUND SLOWLY

Vibe-Coded Micro-SaaS.

Until 2024, building a SaaS required a co-founder, six months, and capital. In 2026, you can ship a working tool in a weekend using Cursor, v0, Lovable, Bolt, or Replit Agent. Most micro-SaaS will fail. That's fine. The cost of failure is now small enough that you can run 3-5 launches a year and let the winners compound.

BEST FOR	TIME TO LAUNCH	PER-TOOL MRR	PORTFOLIO TARGET
Builders · Founders	1 weekend - 4 weeks	\$50 - \$5,000	3-5 / year

The micro-SaaS hunting formula

Pick a narrow audience (real estate agents in Mumbai, indie YouTubers under 5K subs, Indian CA firms). Find a workflow they hate that takes them 30+ minutes a week. Wrap it in an AI flow. Charge \$9 / \$19 / \$49 a month. **Do not try to please everyone** — please one tribe so much that they evangelize you.

Build stack

Cursor + Next.js + Supabase + Stripe.
Or full-vibe: Lovable / v0 / Bolt for the whole app. Vercel for hosting.

AI stack

Claude / OpenAI APIs for inference.
Anthropic + OpenAI keys. LangChain only if you genuinely need it.

Payments

Stripe for global. Razorpay / Cashfree for India. Lemon Squeezy if you want to skip the merchant-of-record headache.

Hosting + ops

Vercel for the app. Cloudflare for DNS.
Resend for transactional email. Posthog for analytics.

Where to launch (channels that actually move the needle)

Launch platforms		Distribution	
Product Hunt	Day 1 spike	X build-in-public	Daily
Hacker News	Show HN	Reddit (niche subs)	Surgical
BetaList	Pre-launch	LinkedIn (founder mode)	3× / wk
Microlaunch	Indie	YouTube tutorial	Long tail
Indie Hackers	Community	Niche newsletters	Sponsorships
Peerlist	India indie	SEO programmatic	Compounding

Pricing tiers

- **Free tier** — hook. Make it generous enough that they get a real win.
- **Starter** — \$9 / month. The "I want to try this seriously" tier.
- **Pro** — \$19 / month. The default, where most of your revenue lives.
- **Team** — \$49 / month. Seats, admin, priority support.
- **Annual prepay** — 2 months free. Cash up front, lower churn.
- **Lifetime (early)** — \$199. Only at launch, only first 100 users.



Reality check

The hard part of micro-SaaS is *not* the building. It's the distribution. If you can't get 100 strangers excited about your idea, no AI tool will save you.

Spend 50% of your time on distribution, even at launch. Especially at launch.

// PATH FIVE · BUILD ASSISTANTS FOR HIRE

Custom GPTs & Gemini Gems.

There are millions of Custom GPTs in the world. Almost all of them are bad — generic prompt wrappers no one uses twice. The opportunity is in the boring middle: building niche, well-trained, well-documented assistants for specific businesses, and getting paid for the build, not the listing.

BEST FOR	TIME PER BUILD	PER BUILD	3-GPT SYSTEM
B2B-comfortable freelancers	1-3 weeks	\$300 - \$2.4K	\$1.8K - \$4.8K

The two business models

Model A · Build-for-hire (recommended)

You build a Custom GPT (or Gemini Gem) for a specific company, trained on their data, deployed inside their workflow. You get paid per build + optional retainer for updates. **This is where the money is.**

Model B · Build-for-distribution

You publish public Custom GPTs targeting a niche, drive traffic to them via LinkedIn / SEO / X, and use them as top-of-funnel for consults, courses, and inbound leads. Slower, but compounds.

High-demand GPT niches

- **Real estate** — listing copy, lead qualifying, neighborhood research.
- **Law firms** — clause-checker, brief summarizer, junior-paralegal GPT.
- **D2C marketing** — ad copy in brand voice, product description engine.
- **HR teams** — JD writer, candidate-screen prompt, interview question generator.
- **CA / financial advisors** — tax explainer, client-summary writer.

- **Educators** — assignment grader, lesson-plan writer, parent-update generator.
- **Sales teams** — discovery-call prompt, email follow-up writer, CRM enrichment.

The build-for-hire workflow

01 Pick a niche.

Pick one. Real estate. Law. D2C. Stop being a generalist.

02 Find 30 SMBs in that niche.

LinkedIn Sales Navigator search · Google Maps · industry directories.

03 Send a "free workflow audit" offer.

"30-min call. I'll find 3 places AI saves your team 5+ hours a week. No pitch."

04 Audit their actual workflow.

Watch them work. Ask what's slow. Note the repetitive bits.

05 Propose 1-3 GPTs.

Each tied to a specific time-saved number. Not "we'll do AI" — "we'll save you 12 hours / week."

06 Build, train, deploy.

Train on their docs / templates / past deliverables. Deliver inside their tooling.

07 Hand over with a 30-min Loom.

Plus a Notion SOP. Plus a 30-day check-in.

08 Sell the retainer.

"\$180 / month and I keep these GPTs sharp + ship one new one a quarter."

Pricing anchor

A single well-built GPT for a real estate firm in Bangalore should price at **\$500-\$720**. A 3-GPT system + 4-hour team training + Notion playbook should price at **\$1.8K-\$2.4K flat**.

Do not underprice. The buyer is comparing you to a junior hire (\$500 / month, full year) — not to a YouTube tutorial.

// PATH SIX · CREATIVE PRODUCTION AT 10× SPEED

AI Content & Video Production.

Image and video generation tools have collapsed the cost of production. A two-person team can now ship the creative output of a 10-person agency. If you came out of the Mastermind comfortable with Midjourney, Runway, Sora, Veo, Kling, and ElevenLabs — this is the path with the fastest visual proof and the most photogenic case studies.

BEST FOR	TIME TO FIRST \$	PROJECT PRICE	RETAINER RANGE
Creators · Designers	2-6 weeks	\$180 - \$1.2K	\$500 - \$1.8K / mo

Services you can sell

- 01 D2C ad creative packs.**
10-30 image + 5-10 video variants per month for performance-marketing teams. \$500-\$960 / month.
- 02 Faceless YouTube channel production.**
Hindi or English. Finance / history / mythology / business niches. \$600-\$1.8K / month per channel.
- 03 Short-form for B2B brands.**
LinkedIn / Instagram videos using AI b-roll, voiceover, captions. \$350-\$850 / month.
- 04 AI ecom photoshoots.**
Replace \$1.2K+ studio shoots with AI-generated lifestyle shots. \$300-\$1.2K per "shoot."
- 05 Course / cohort visuals.**
Slide decks, thumbnails, lesson covers for course creators. Easy retainer.

06 Music videos / lyric videos / album art.

Indie musicians, podcast cover art, audiogram visuals.

07 UGC-style ads (synthetic).

Hot category. Synthetic spokespeople for D2C ads. Disclose appropriately.

The tool stack

- **Storyboarding** — ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini.
- **Image** — Midjourney, Imagen, Flux, Ideogram.
- **Video** — Runway, Sora, Veo, Kling, Hailuo, Higgsfield, Luma.
- **Voice** — ElevenLabs, Murf, Cartesia.
- **Music** — Suno, Udio.
- **Edit** — CapCut, DaVinci, Descript, OpusClip, Submagic.

Who to pitch

- D2C brands (skincare, F&B, fashion) doing performance ads.
- Edtech & coaching businesses making YouTube content.
- Real estate agencies needing listing-walkthrough videos.
- Finance / business YouTubers tired of stock footage.
- B2B SaaS marketing teams needing LinkedIn video.
- Course creators on Whop, Skool, Maven, Graphy.
- Wedding photographers (AI pre-shoot mood boards, post-edit).

The portfolio hack

Pick 5 brands you'd love to work with. Make **unsolicited spec creative** for each — 3 ad variants you'd ship if they were already a client. DM the creative head with the work. *Show, don't pitch.* This converts at a shockingly high rate.

// PATH SEVEN · TEACH WHAT YOU SHIP

Cohorts, Communities & Coaching.

The fastest-growing income category in the creator economy is "learn from someone who shipped." If you've used your Mastermind skills to deliver real outcomes — even on Path 01 or 02 — you can teach others how to do it. The margins are 90%+. The scale is 1-to-many. The hard prerequisite is having actually shipped something.

BEST FOR	COHORT PRICE	COHORT REVENUE	COMMUNITY MRR
After 3+ mo on Path 01/02/04	\$35 - \$300 / seat	\$2.4K - \$30K / launch	\$600 - \$6K / month

Four revenue models, ranked by effort

- 01

Topmate 1:1 coaching.

Easiest start. \$6-\$35 / 30 min. Capped income but immediate. Use this to validate that people will pay you for advice in your niche before scaling up.
- 02

Workshops & one-off events.

3-hour workshops via Lu.ma, Konfhub, Eventbrite. \$6-\$60 / seat. Great for testing topics and warm leads. No long delivery commitment.
- 03

Cohort courses.

Live, time-bound, small groups. Hosted on Maven, Graphy, or Skool. \$60-\$300 / seat × 30-100 seats. This is where the money lives.
- 04

Paid communities.

Skool / Circle / WhatsApp+ at \$6-\$25 / month. Highest LTV. Hardest to sustain — needs daily presence or moderators. Pair with a cohort.

Cohort topics that sell in 2026

TOPIC	WHY IT WORKS
AI for Lawyers	Niche-by-job-role. Tight ICP, easy targeting, premium pricing.
ChatGPT for Realtors	Tier-2/3 city realtors will pay \$60-\$180 to learn from someone who's been there.
Build Your First Custom GPT	Beginner-friendly, repeatable, easy to fill 100-seat cohorts at \$35 each.
AI Workflows for Founders	Premium audience. \$180-\$300 / seat. Recorded testimonials sell the next cohort.
Faceless YT Channel in 30 Days	High-demand, results-driven, photogenic. Easy waitlist.
AI for HR & Recruiting	B2B-flavored, corporate sponsorship potential, easy upsell to internal training.

Don't teach what you just learned

Wait until you've used your skills to **ship for at least 3 paying clients** on Path 01 or 02 before you launch a cohort. Otherwise you're teaching theory. *The market has had enough theory. Teach receipts.*

// PATH EIGHT · FOR THE STILL-EMPLOYED

The In-House AI Champion.

Not everyone wants to leave their job. Not everyone should. The under-discussed monetization path is using your Mastermind skills inside your current employer — to engineer a 30-100% comp uplift, a new title, or a transition into roles that pay double what you make today. Done well, this is the highest ROI path in the playbook.

BEST FOR	TIME HORIZON	COMP UPLIFT	RISK
Working professionals	3-9 months	+30 - +100%	Lowest of all 8

The 90-day in-house playbook

- 01

Audit your team's workflows.

List every recurring task. Mark the ones that take more than 30 minutes a week. Those are your targets.
- 02

Pick 3 workflows. Build Custom GPTs / Gems for them.

Train on your team's docs. Test on real tasks. Quantify time saved.
- 03

Run a "lunch & learn" session.

30 minutes. Show the team. Hand them the GPTs. Become the AI person by demonstration.
- 04

Document everything in Notion.

Workflow before. Workflow after. Time saved. Cost saved. This is your case study.
- 05

Post on LinkedIn — with permission.

"How we automated X at [Company]." Your manager looks like a leader. You become the visible face.

06 Volunteer for the AI strategy conversation.

Every leadership team is having this meeting. Be the person they invite.

07 Negotiate explicitly.

"I saved the team N hours / week = \$X / year. I'd like a Y% raise / a new title / to lead the AI initiative."

Emerging roles that didn't exist 24 months ago

ROLE	SCOPE	INDIA COMP
Head of AI Operations	Owens AI rollout across functions. Often non-engineering.	\$42K – \$120K
AI Product Manager	PM-flavored role focused on AI features. PM background + Mastermind = qualified.	\$30K – \$85K
AI Solutions Architect	Often non-technical. Maps business problems to AI solutions.	\$36K – \$96K
AI Workflow Designer	Builds internal Custom GPTs / agents for ops, sales, HR teams.	\$22K – \$48K
AI Enablement Lead	Trains the company on AI. Internal cohorts + SOPs + audits.	\$24K – \$60K
Prompt Engineer	Pure prompt + eval work. Increasingly folded into other roles.	\$18K – \$42K

The stack move

Path 08 is not exclusive. You can **stack it with Path 01, 03, or 05**. Use your day job as your case-study factory and your salary as your runway. Three months in, you'll either get the raise (great) or land a side income that exceeds your salary (also great).

// THE PLATFORM STACK — WHERE TO LIVE ONLINE

The full stack.

A monetization business is a stack of platforms — for finding clients, delivering work, getting paid, and compounding distribution. Pick one per category. Don't sprawl across ten apps for the same job.

Lead generation & audience

LinkedIn	India B2B · #1
X / Twitter	Global tech
YouTube (long-form)	Authority
Instagram & YT Shorts	Mass reach
Newsletter (Beehiiv / Substack)	Owned
Reddit (niche subs)	Surgical

Outreach / sales

LinkedIn Sales Navigator	Targeting
Apollo.io	Lead data
Instantly / Smartlead	Cold email
Lemlist	Personalized
Hunter / Snov	Email finder
Clay	Enrichment

Productized / course / community

Skool	Community + course
Circle	Premium community
Maven	Cohort courses
Graphy / Teachable	India / global

Freelance marketplaces

Upwork	Global
Contra	Global · no fees
Fiverr / Fiverr Pro	Productized
Toptal	Premium
Topmate	India · 1:1
Refrens	India · invoice + gigs

Payments & invoicing

Razorpay / Cashfree	India
Refrens	India invoice
Stripe	Global SaaS
Wise / Payoneer	Cross-border
Deel	Contractor pay
Lemon Squeezy	MoR for SaaS

Portfolio & sites

v0 / Lovable / Bolt	Vibe-coded
Framer	Designed
Notion + Super.so	Fastest
Carrd	One-pager

Whop	Creator products
Lu.ma / Konfhub	Workshops

Beacons / Linktree	Bio link
Peerlist	India indie

Productivity / delivery

Notion	SOPs & CRM
Loom	Async handoff
Slack	Client comms
ChatGPT Team / Plus	Daily driver
Claude Pro	Long-form
Cursor	Vibe-coding

Launch (for SaaS / tools)

Product Hunt	Launch day
Hacker News (Show HN)	Traffic spike
BetaList / Microlaunch	Pre-launch
Indie Hackers	Community
Peerlist Launchpad	India indie
Reddit (r/SideProject)	Indie crowd

// YOUR FIRST QUARTER, WEEK BY WEEK

Ninety days from here to your first \$.

A specific, week-by-week plan. Adjust the path, but keep the structure. The single biggest mistake we see is people spending three months "preparing" without ever shipping. This roadmap is shipping-first.

DAYS 01-30 · BUILD THE FOUNDATION

WEEK 01 · PICK & COMMIT

Pick one path. Pick one niche. Write a 1-line offer. Tell three people you're doing it. *Public commitment is fuel.*

WEEK 02 · SPEC WORK

Build 3 spec pieces — fake-client work that proves the outcome you sell. Post each one on LinkedIn / X with a breakdown.

WEEK 03 · SET UP SHOP

Vibe-code a portfolio. Write LinkedIn featured. Set up Topmate. Set up Refrens / Razorpay. Refresh your bio everywhere with the new offer.

WEEK 04 · BEGIN OUTBOUND

10 cold DMs / day. 5 cold emails / day. 3 posts / week. *The job this month is volume of contact.*

WEEK 05 • FIRST CONVERSION

Land your first paid client. Charge less than you'd like — this round is for proof, not income. Even \$60–\$180 is fine.

WEEK 06 • DELIVER HARD

Over-deliver on the first project. Document everything. Record a Loom case study with their permission.

WEEK 07 • TESTIMONIALS

Ask for a testimonial in writing + on video if possible. Post the case study publicly. *One real outcome beats ten years of theory posts.*

WEEK 08 • LAND 2 MORE

Use the case study to land clients 2 and 3. Raise your price 30–50%. By end of month 2: 3 paying clients, \$300–\$900 total revenue.

DAYS 61-90 • SCALE THE WINS

WEEK 09 • PRODUCTIZE

Look at what you've delivered. Pick the highest-margin offer. Productize it — fixed scope, fixed price, sales page.

WEEK 10 • RETAINER PUSH

Pitch each existing client a monthly retainer. Even a 50% conversion rate = recurring revenue. Aim for \$500+ / month MRR by end of week 12.

WEEK 11 • COMPOUND CONTENT

By now you have receipts. Step up content cadence to 5–7 / week. Write the case studies. Tag the clients. *Watch inbound start.*

WEEK 12 • DECIDE

Review the data. Stay on this path? Layer on Path 03 (creator) or Path 02 (productize)? Decide. Plan the next 90 days.

// REAL NUMBERS · USD

What to charge.

Three pricing models. Use them all. Pick the right one for the right deal. Pricing is a confidence game more than a math game — but knowing the math gives you the confidence.

Three models, in order of sophistication

MODEL	HOW IT WORKS	WHEN TO USE IT	TRAP TO AVOID
Hourly	Sell time. \$6–\$200 / hr depending on market and seniority.	Discovery / consulting calls only. Don't deliver projects this way.	Penalises you for getting better & faster.
Project	Fixed scope, fixed price. \$180–\$2.4K per project.	Anything with a clear deliverable. Most freelance work.	Scope creep without a change-order clause.
Retainer	Monthly recurring fee for an outcome / scope. \$500–\$3.6K / month.	Anyone you've delivered for once. Always pitch this.	Vague scope = burnout. Define an hour-cap or deliverable-cap.

Global · typical ranges (USD)

SERVICE	PROJECT	RETAINER / MONTH
Custom GPT / Gem build	\$500 – \$5,000	\$300 – \$1,500
Productized service (writing / creative)	—	\$1,000 – \$8,000
AI consulting / advisory	\$2,000 – \$20,000	\$2,000 – \$10,000
Workflow automation (n8n + AI)	\$1,500 – \$10,000	\$800 – \$4,000
AI ad creative / video production	\$1,000 – \$8,000	\$1,500 – \$6,000

// TEMPLATES · DM, EMAIL, VOICE NOTE

The outreach playbook.

First contact is where most monetization dies. The fix is not to write longer messages or hire a copywriter. The fix is to be specific, useful, and low-friction. Below: scripts that actually get replies, in 2026.

LinkedIn cold DM (best performer for India B2B)

LINKEDIN DM · 60 WORDS · DELETE THE PITCH

Hey {{first_name}} — saw your post on {{specific topic}}. Loved the {{specific point}} bit.

Quick one: a few {{their industry}} teams I've worked with were losing ~10 hrs/week on {{specific workflow}}. I built them a Custom GPT that cut that to 2.

Happy to share the playbook (no pitch, just the prompt + workflow). Want me to send it over?

Cold email (outcome-led, four lines)

COLD EMAIL · SUBJECT & BODY

Subject: 12 hrs / week back for {{company}}?

Hi {{first_name}},

I help {{industry}} teams cut their {{specific workflow}} from 15 hours / week to under 3 — using Custom GPTs trained on their own SOPs.

Two examples: {{client A — outcome}}, {{client B — outcome}}.

Worth a 20-min call next week to see if the same applies to {{company}}?

— {{your name}}

Follow-up (day 3 & day 7)

FOLLOW-UP 01 · DAY 3

Hi {{first_name}} — bumping this. I built a quick Loom (3 min) showing exactly the workflow I'd set up for {{company}}. Want me to send it?

FOLLOW-UP 02 · DAY 7 · BREAK-UP

Hi {{first_name}} — last note from me. If now isn't the right time, totally fair. Mind if I send the Loom anyway? You can keep it whether we work together or not.

The Loom hack — biggest unlock of this playbook

Record a 2–3 minute Loom *specifically for the prospect*. Show their website / LinkedIn / company. Show the exact GPT or workflow you'd build. Send the link in your DM. **Conversion rates 3–10× higher than cold text.** The Loom proves you've done the work, not just read the script.

The numbers that work

Daily target: **10 LinkedIn DMs + 5 cold emails + 1 Loom.** Five days a week. Four weeks. Expect 5–8% reply rate, 1–2% conversion to call, 30–50% close on calls.

Math: *~300 contacts → ~15 calls → ~5 clients.* That's the entire game.

// WHAT KILLS MONETIZATION · AVOID ALL SEVEN

Seven things that kill your AI business.

We have watched hundreds of attendees go through Mastermind cohorts. The ones who fail to monetize tend to fail in the same seven ways. Print this page. Stick it next to your laptop.

01 Tutorial-hopping.

Watching one more video instead of shipping. The market does not care how many courses you've completed. The market cares what you've delivered.

Cure: ban yourself from new courses for 90 days.

02 Selling the tool, not the outcome.

"I know ChatGPT" is not an offer. "I save your sales team 10 hours a week" is. Lead with the time / money / pain you remove.

Cure: rewrite every sentence in your pitch as a buyer outcome.

03 Generalist positioning.

"AI for businesses" is "AI for nobody." Pick one industry. Pick one role inside that industry. Pick one workflow. Get famous in that pinhole.

Cure: write a 20-word ICP. Tape it to your monitor.

04 Fear-pricing.

Quoting \$60 because you're scared they'll say no to \$600. Underpricing trains both your nervous system and the market.

Cure: quote 30% higher than your gut. Watch how few say no.

05 Hiding from outbound.

Every freelancer who fails is the one who waited for inbound. Cold outreach is unglamorous and it works.

Cure: **50 contacts per week, non-negotiable, for 90 days.**

06 Not collecting proof.

No testimonials, no screenshots, no Looms, no case studies. You are invisible without receipts.

Cure: **document every win — photo, screenshot, video, quote — within 24 hours of getting it.**

07 Building in private.

Your portfolio is your daily LinkedIn / X / YouTube feed, not a hidden Notion page. If the market can't find you, the market can't pay you.

Cure: **ship 5 pieces a week. Show the work, including the unfinished parts.**

The meta-pitfall

All seven killers share a root: *preferring the comfort of preparation to the discomfort of contact with the market*. The market is the only honest teacher. Get rejected, get feedback, recalibrate. Repeat.

// CLOSING THOUGHTS · RE-READ EVERY QUARTER

The operator's mindset.

Skill plus mindset is what compounds. Without the mindset, the skill rusts. Below are nine principles we'd want every Outskill graduate to internalize before they close this document.

01 **Sell outcomes, not artefacts.**

Nobody buys "a Custom GPT." They buy "12 hours back per week." Translate every offer.

02 **Niche down ruthlessly.**

"AI for D2C beauty brands under \$6M revenue" beats "AI consulting" — every single time.

03 **Distribute as much as you build.**

In 2026, distribution is the moat. The best builder with no audience loses to the average builder with one.

04 **Ship in public.**

Your build log is your portfolio. Your mistakes are your magnetism. Your output is your CV.

05 **Charge what creates pressure to deliver.**

Cheap clients pay you in cash but cost you in soul. Premium clients pay you in cash, referrals, and standards.

06 **Compound through testimonials.**

One specific, video, named testimonial beats ten anonymous "great work!" quotes. Collect aggressively.

07 **Pick paths that stack.**

Path 01 → Path 02 → Path 03 → Path 07 is one of the cleanest stacks. Each layer fuels the next.

08 **Treat your skill like an athlete treats a sport.**

Daily reps. Weekly review. Quarterly reset. The market will reward training, not talent.

09 **Pay the future-you tax.**

Every week, do one thing only future-you will thank you for: a long-form post, a case study, a new GPT, a Loom asset. They compound.

"You don't get paid for what you know. You get paid for what you ship — and who can find you when they need it."

// FINAL PAGE · THE ONLY THING THAT MATTERS

Close this. Open a blank doc.

*If you remember one thing from this playbook, remember this: the people who monetize are not the most talented. They are the ones who took action within 48 hours of finishing the workshop. **That window is right now.***

TONIGHT · 60 MINUTES

- ✓ Pick one path (page 05). Write it on paper.
- ✓ Pick one niche within it. Write it on paper.
- ✓ Write a one-line offer: "I help [niche] do [outcome] using [skill]."
- ✓ Update your LinkedIn headline to match.
- ✓ Tell three people — out loud or in writing — what you're doing for the next 90 days.

THIS WEEK

- ✓ Build 3 spec pieces / case studies — fake-client, real-quality.
 - ✓ Set up your minimum stack: Topmate, LinkedIn featured, Refrens / Razorpay.
 - ✓ Start your outbound: 10 DMs / day, 5 emails / day, 3 posts / week.
 - ✓ Bookmark this playbook and re-read it every 30 days.
-

Build, ship, get paid.

The skills are in your head. The playbook is in your hands. The market is waiting. Everything you need is already on this device. *The only thing missing is the next 90 days.*

Share back

When you land your first paying client, post about it and tag **@outskill**. We celebrate every alumnus who ships. The next cohort needs to see your case study to believe what's possible.

Ship something this week.